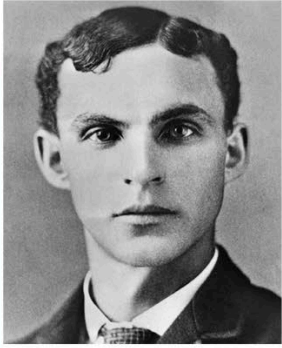


Henry Ford



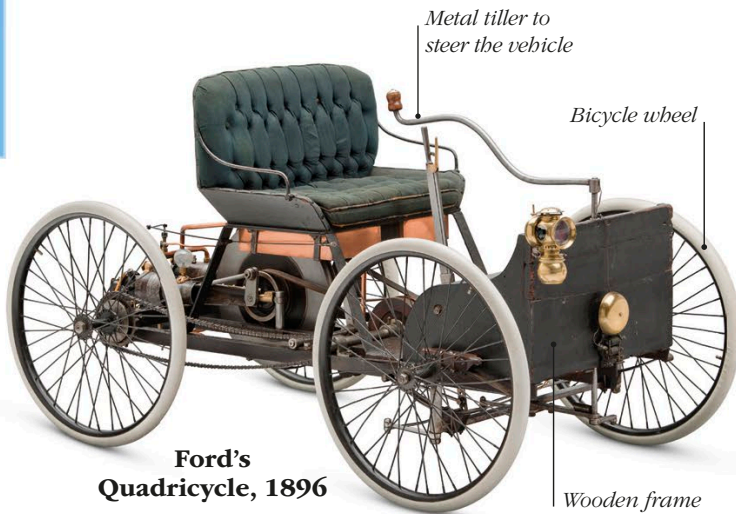
The American industrialist Henry Ford made history by launching the affordable Ford Model T (see pp.92–93). By using a simple design and mass-producing this car in a giant factory, he turned the motor vehicle from a luxury item for the rich into an everyday item for the masses. If it weren't for Ford, cars today might have been as rare as luxury yachts.

A CAR FOR EVERYBODY

The speed of the production line meant that Ford could keep up with demand. By 1914, Ford was rolling out more than a quarter of a million cars every year—half of all cars made in the US.

► THE MODEL T

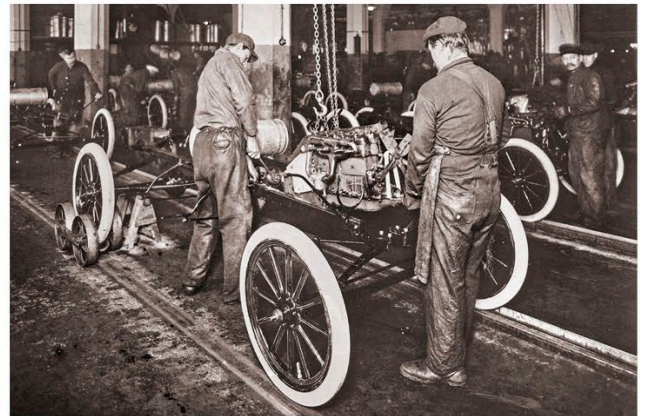
Henry Ford stands next to one of his Model Ts, c. 1920. Made of lightweight steel, this car was robust and easy to maintain.



Ford's
Quadricycle, 1896

KEEPING IT SIMPLE

Ford's first car—the simple, cheap Quadricycle of 1896—was little more than a gasoline engine mounted on four bicycle wheels. This single-seater had twin drive belts (see p.90) that could be operated using a floor-mounted clutch. His idea was to build a car that could be manufactured quickly and in large numbers by laborers, not carefully crafted by skilled coach builders.



ASSEMBLY LINE

Ford factory manager Charles Sorensen introduced the assembly line in 1913. Each car was dragged along rails by a chain and each worker added a part—the same one each time. This nonstop process churned out a new car every 10 seconds.

LIFE STORY

1863

Son of William and Mary, Henry Ford is born on July 30 in Wayne County, Michigan.

1876

He dismantles and rebuilds a pocket watch given to him by his father. The young Ford starts repairing watches for others.

1879

Ford leaves home to become an apprentice machinist in Detroit, where he learns to handle steam engines.

1896

Ford makes the Quadricycle, and test-drives it in Detroit.

